

Eichmann, Exodus, and Entebbe

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The Reading Room, a government run library on Reading Room Road (no surprise), was an oasis for book enthusiasts in small town Arsikere. It had a good collection of Kannada books and a motley set of English books that included RK Narayan, Gandhi, Thackeray and sundries. It also subscribed to many magazines and newspapers. An early memory that hasn't faded much is of sitting on a bench in the outer room and reading an article that described, or perhaps referenced in some detail, the dramatic capture of Adolf Eichmann by Israeli agents in Argentina, his secret transport to Israel, and his trial. This piqued my interest in all things Israel.

A reinforcement of this interest is due to the circulating library, our go-to source for the then popular paperbacks---Alistair Maclean, Irving Wallace, and the like. *Exodus*, by Leon Uris, was their fattest book. A friend dared me to read the whole book, around 700 pages, and I took him up on it. It had to be read quickly, else the fees would accumulate. The book was fascinating enough to not only read, but also reread parts. It tells the spectacular (fictionalized, as I learn later) story about how Palestine was settled by Jews and eventually became the state of Israel.

The interest was cemented by a third source. On my way to the evening friends' gathering, I would usually pass by the book shack at our Bus Stand, gawk at the covers of books by James Hadley Chase and wonder what the many books by Cheiro were all about. The owner, being a family friend, usually lent us magazines and books for overnight reading. Once I took home *Ninety Minutes at Entebbe*, an odd book for the store and much slimmer than *Exodus*. This book is about the rescue operation by Israeli agents of hostages in a hijacked plane that was parked in faraway Uganda overseen by the hijacker-friendly of Idi Amin.

I was now fixated on Israelis. News about Golda Meir and the inevitable comparison with Indira Gandhi, secret visits of Moshe Dayan (he with the eyepatches) to India and many other stories now came into focus. And then I started exploring Jewish writers; Saul Bellow and Isaac Singer are still my favourites. Later in life I came to Mumbai and the Jew bug continued. I visited the local synagogues, discovered the legacy of David Sassoon (Flora Fountain, his library and docks), read up on Nissim Ezekiel and his poems, was thankful for the leadership of Gen. JFR Jacob and even had a Jewish student.

I must thank Payal for this reminiscence. Recently, Payal, a Baaraati horse, broke loose from its handler and started trotting down Worli Sea Link. After nearly half an hour of traffic disruption, Payal was finally apprehended, calmed, and brought under control by a some Israeli tourists, who were nearby. This was so much in-character with the persona of an Israeli that I had built up that I began to trace back the origins of my awareness and interest in Israel. Even as I became wistful about the three wonderful institutions in a small town that started me on a reading habit and helped keep it alive. Before TV, computer, and phone changed it all forever.